Eras and periods

Scientists name chunks of geological time according to three broad **eras**. These are modern (**Cainozoic**), middle (**Mesozoic**) and ancient (**Paleozoic**). Each of these eras is divided into **periods**.

☞ **1** Use the word bank to complete the table below.

Word bank

Jurassic insects middle species fish

mammals Devonian Extinction birds Tertiary

Era	Period		Description
Cainozoic (recent life) modern to 65 million years ago	Quaternary		• Mostly modern s_____ • **Megafauna** around the world
	T_____		• Modern animal groups • Australia separates from Antarctica • Expansion of m_____ throughout the world
Mesozoic (middle life) 65 million to 250 million years ago	Cretaceous	late	E_____ of many groups of vertebrates
		m_____	• World's earliest known marsupials • Australian giant amphibian *Koolasuchus cleelandi*
		early	Australian dinosaur *Muttaburrasaurus langdoni*
	J_____		World's oldest b_____
	Triassic		World's oldest mammals
Palaeozoic 250 million to 542 million years ago	Permian		**Glaciers** throughout Australia
	Carboniferous		• World's oldest reptiles • Giant i_____
	D_____		World's oldest amphibians
	Silurian		Land turns green
	Ordovician		World's first f_____
	Cambrian		World's oldest vertebrates

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